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Sievan Paints a Lyric Queens Landscape

By HILTON KRAMER

In the retrospective exhibition of paintings and drawings by Maurice Sievan that is now on view in the Queens Museum at the Queens County Art and Cultural Center, there are early works (from 1912 through the nineteen-twenties) in the romantic-academic style of the turn of the century, and there are late paintings (from the nineteen-sixties) in a style of lyrical abstraction. But the principal focus of the exhibition, which numbers 69 items, is on the artist's landscape paintings. It is indeed as a landscape painter that Mr. Sievan has produced his most distinctive work.

Many of these landscapes draw their motifs from locations in Queens, where Mr. Sievan lived from 1940 to 1966. (At 75, the artist now lives and works in Manhattan.) For demographers and urban-design specialists, Queens may have become in this period a representative example of accelerating and inelegant urban growth, but for Mr. Sievan it remained a source of lyric inspiration. His depictions of Utopia Parkway, Astoria Boulevard and the Corona landscape evoke a pastoral imagery in which hard-edge, helter-skelter development is nowhere to be seen.

In the present exhibition, several of these Queens landscapes are juxtaposed to photographs of the actual site depicted. (Mr. Sievan always painted directly from nature in a mobile studio rigged up

in his car.) Yet the effect of these photographs is not to confirm the value of his paintings as visual documents but rather to underscore the quality of their visual invention. What engaged the artist's emotions was not the motif so much as the painterly values it enabled him to realize.

The landscape is not merely transformed by the painter's style; it is virtually swallowed up in the quick painterly "handwriting" that is the special delight of Mr. Sievan's work. This is an art that takes immense pleasure in the visual and even the physical properties of the medium—in that lyrical orchestration of squiggles and loops of pigment that make of every subject a very personal statement of feeling.

What I have called the "handwriting" in Mr. Sievan's landscape paintings reminds one of Soutine's in its nervous energy and headlong emotion, but the light is the gray, even light of Corot. The risk here is a certain murkiness, which Mr. Sievan's work does not always escape; yet it is clearly a risk that answers to a deeply felt visual imperative. Mr. Sievan sees the world in a certain light, as we say, and when he captures it, it is a personal triumph.

Beyond the pastoral evocations of the landscape paintings, the present exhibition is interesting, too, for the series of self-portrait

drawings and paintings. The earliest of these is a drawing from 1913 in which the artist's handsome, thoughtful features are portrayed with romantic elegance. The later self-portraits grow increasingly detached and dour until, in the end, the literal features of the face give way to a strongly stated pictorial idea.

There are also some fine portrait drawings of the artist's contemporaries, including an especially moving one of Abraham Walkowitz—No. 8 in the catalogue—that is a beauty. This should certainly find its way into some museum collection of American art.

Through the myriad and often disrupting turns of styles and movements of the 20th century, Mr. Sievan has followed a course of his own, remaining loyal to the old-fashioned values he cherished. At times this has placed his art at a considerable distance from the big excitements of the art world, but it has also enabled him to produce something individual and inward. There is an integrity and a dedication in the work that transcend its occasional failures, and one is delighted to see it recognized in this exhibition.

The Queens Museum, where the show remains on view through April 21, is in Flushing Meadow-Corona Park, and its hours are noon to 5, Tuesday through Friday, 10 to 5 on Saturday, 1 to 5 on Sunday.